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The Feminist Poetics of Emily Dickinson and Emma Lazarus

In a literary world that favored male voices and rigid poetic forms, Emily Dickinson and Emma Lazarus challenged the norms. Though they differed in background and poetic style, they both used their poems to challenge the expectations placed upon them. Through their poetry, Emily Dickinson and Emma Lazarus both used poetic forms to express feminist themes, each reflecting their resistance to these societal expectations of women. Dickinson used hymn-like stanzas and unconventional punctuation to critique the restrictive roles imposed on women in her poems, such as “Much Madness is divinest Sense” and “The Soul selects her own Society,” while Lazarus used assertive sonnets as a tool for empowerment and social advocacy in her poems, such as “The New Colossus” and “Echoes.” Both poets challenge traditional gender roles and assert their feminist voices through their manipulation of poetic structures, offering alternative perspectives on women's autonomy and societal roles.

To understand the feminist themes in their work, it is important to consider the cultural pressures of their time. When discussing nineteenth-century America, Carroll Smith-Rosenberg states, “The ideal female in nineteenth-century America was expected to be gentle and refined, sensitive and loving. She was the guardian of religion and spokeswoman for morality... The American girl was taught at home, at school, and in the literature of the period that aggression, independence, self-assertion, and curiosity were male traits, inappropriate for the weaker sex and

her limited sphere. Dependent throughout her life, she was to reward her male protectors with affection and submission. At no time was she expected to achieve in any area considered important by men and thus highly valued by society” (655-656). This means that these poets were expected to live a life where they were not only dependent upon someone else, but also socially and academically passive. They were not encouraged to create or express themselves in public, especially not through literature, which was seen as a serious and male-dominated field. Any ambition they had was expected to remain private or be redirected into domestic duties. Yet both Dickinson and Lazarus defied these expectations by writing boldly and with purpose.

Emily Dickinson, born in 1830 in Amherst, Massachusetts, received a education at Amherst Academy and Mount Holyoke Female Seminary but became increasingly reclusive in her late twenties, preferring to stay at home and avoid social engagements. Although her outward life was quiet, her inner life was intense and creative, with her writing over a thousand poems.

Though Dickinson wrote prolifically, only a handful of her poems were published during her lifetime, as her unique style, known for its unconventional punctuation and irregular rhythms, did not align with the literary trends of her time. Her reclusiveness and resistance to publishing reflected her desire for privacy and autonomy, and her poems often challenged the restrictive gender roles of her era (Knights 358-359).

Emily Dickinson frequently wrote in the common meter, specifically in iambic tetrameter and trimeter. This is a hymn-like structure that Dickinson used to express her unorthodox messages in a way that couldn't be silenced. This was useful to her as hymns typically make one think of conformity and submission. Dickinson was able to manipulation this form to serve as a subtle critique of the gendered expectations placed on women in her time. By using hymnal

stanzas, Dickinson exposes the tension between society's demands for women's conformity and the intellectual autonomy expressed through her poetry.

In Emily Dickinson's poems "Much Madness is divinest Sense" (Poem 620) and "The Soul selects her own Society" (Poem 409), her use of form and structure serves as a powerful tool to challenge the societal norms and expectations regarding women's roles. Both poems defy the conventional ideas of femininity and womanhood that were imposed during Dickinson's time, using the structure to underline their rebellious messages.

In "Much Madness is divinest Sense," the poem's use of common meter creates an expectation of predictability that is commonly associated with hymnal structure. However, Dickinson disrupts this expected order with irregular punctuation and capitalization, indicating a deliberate departure from conformity. The rhythm is regular, but the pauses and breaks in punctuation challenge the smooth flow of the meter, creating a tension that reflects the speaker's resistance to the majority's definition of "sanity." These pauses in the structure emphasizes the feminist theme of rejecting societal norms that attempt to control women's behavior and intellect.

An example of this from the poem is when it says, "Much Sense - the starkest Madness - / 'Tis the Majority / In this, as all, prevail -" (Dickinson 3-5). The breaks in rhythm that are present in this poem display how Dickinson is equating "madness" with "sense." By placing these seemingly contradictory terms side by side, Dickinson reveals the instability of the definitions imposed by society. What is labeled as "madness" may actually be the truth, and what is called "sense" may just be what dominant society considers the norm. The line "'Tis the Majority / In this, as all, prevail" suggests that societal definitions of sanity are determined not by truth or reason, but by those in power. This critique mirrors the way women's thoughts,

choices, and independence have historically been invalidated by those who define what is “normal.”

Another example from this poem are the lines, “Assent - and you are sane - / Demur - you’re straightway dangerous - / And handled with a Chain —” (Dickinson 6-8). In these lines, the contrast between the simplicity of “Assent” and the violence of being “handled with a Chain” emphasizes the repercussions that women faced when they would step outside of socially accepted roles. The punctuation here interrupts the flow of the poem, mirroring how nonconformity disrupts the perceived social order. Dickinson’s structural choices reflect the restrictions imposed on women who think independently or refuse to conform, reinforcing the poem’s critique of a system that equates obedience with sanity and autonomy with danger.

In “The Soul selects her own Society,” Dickinson has written this poem to be controlled. This helps to reinforce her speaker’s desire for autonomy. The use of pauses in the poem adds a sense of thoughtfulness and consideration to each decision the speaker makes. This makes it seem as though each choice is carefully weighed and firm. These pauses slow down the rhythm, emphasizing the power of the speaker’s decisions, particularly when rejecting external influences. This controlled form serves the feminist theme by reinforcing the idea of autonomy and self-determination, suggesting that women are entitled to choose their own “Society” without being constrained by societal expectations.

An example of this from the poem is where it says, “Then — shuts the Door — / To her divine Majority — / Present no more —” (Dickinson 2-4). This is an example as the abrupt action of “shutting the door” reflects a deliberate, almost forceful rejection of outside influences. The controlled form here highlights the decisiveness of the speaker in controlling her own space,

rejecting the notion that women should be defined by their relationships or by the pressure of the majority.

Another example of this is when it says, “Then — close the Valves of her attention — / Like Stone —” (Dickinson 11-12). These lines show how the form reflects how firmly the speaker sticks to her decision and reinforces the poem’s message of independence and personal agency. The form mirrors this emotional withdrawal, showing how women can assert control over their intellectual and emotional lives, refusing to be molded by societal expectations. This connects to Dickinson’s feminist message by showing a woman who is choosing for herself, even if that choice means excluding the rest of society. Instead of being open to everyone else’s expectations, she chooses to focus on what matters to her, reflecting a bit towards Dickinson’s reclusive nature.

Together, the form and structure of both poems strengthen Dickinson’s feminist message. In “Much Madness is divinest Sense,” she disrupts traditional meter with irregular punctuation, while in “The Soul selects her own Society,” the irregular pauses reflect careful, self-driven decisions. In both poems, the speaker resists outside definitions and chooses for herself. Dickinson’s use of form helps challenge the roles expected of women and presents a quiet but powerful image of independence and autonomy.

Emma Lazarus was born into a wealthy, well-educated Jewish American family in 1849, and from a young age, she was deeply influenced by both Christian American ideals and Jewish traditions. Unlike many women of her time, Lazarus did not define herself through roles like wife or mother. Instead, she used writing to help define her place in society. In deciding to use poetry as a form of advocacy, Lazarus was directly challenging the cultural expectations placed on women, particularly Jewish women, in the nineteenth century (Lichtenstein 248-249).

Lazarus often wrote in sonnets and free verse, two forms that allowed her to navigate both traditional and emerging styles. Her use of sonnets, which were associated to male poets and romantic themes, involved using them to reflect on society, as well as to show pride in her culture. While her use of free verse broke away from strict poetic rules and reflected her desire for change. By reshaping these forms, Lazarus speaks to the need for women's voices in political and cultural conversations. She does this by using poetry to assert independence and confront the circumstances that limited both her Jewish and female identities.

In Emma Lazarus' poems, "The New Colossus" and "Echoes," the use of form and structure plays a crucial role in conveying her feminist critique of societal expectations. Both of these poems succeed in breaking away from traditional forms to reinterpret established structures. This works to amplify Lazarus' messages about women's autonomy and creative expression. She strategically uses the rigid form of a sonnet in "The New Colossus" to present a powerful female figure, while in "Echoes," the use of free verse reflects the speaker's struggle to assert herself within a male-dominated literary world. Through these structural choices, Lazarus challenges conventional gender roles and advocates for women's voices to be heard in both societal and artistic spaces.

In "The New Colossus," Emma Lazarus uses a highly structured poetic form with a specific rhyme scheme of ABBAABBA CDCDCD, I believe, as well as a formal tone that delivers a message that offers a different view of both national identity and the role of women in society. The organized structure, usually associated with romantic themes, is repurposed by Lazarus to address social issues, giving the poem a sense of authority. This allows Lazarus to introduce a female figure, the "Mother of Exiles," as a symbol of strength, compassion, and

leadership. By placing this figure at the center of a national monument, Lazarus challenges traditional ideas that link power with masculinity.

An example of this how this structure is used is when Lazarus describes this figure as, “A mighty woman with a torch, whose flame / Is the imprisoned lightning, and her name / Mother of Exiles” (Lazarus 4-6). This is an example as the rhyme of "flame" and "name" gives the lines a sense of balance and authority that frames the “Mother of Exiles” as a powerful and enduring symbol. The image of a “mighty woman” holding a torch serves as a direct contrast to traditional depictions of women in this time, as Lazarus is portraying a woman as a symbol of strength and leadership, instead of sticking her into a submissive role. Also, the phrase "imprisoned lightning" adds depth to this image as it is implying that her power, though contained, is still immense and capable of igniting change.

In “Echoes,” Emma Lazarus uses free verse, creating a more fluid structure compared to the structured rhyme scheme in “The New Colossus.” The lack of a fixed meter or rhyme scheme allows the poem to flow more freely, mirroring the speaker’s internal conflict and journey toward self-discovery. The shifts in rhythm and meter reflect the speaker's struggle to find a space for herself within a literary and societal traditions dominated by men. Also, the free verse form emphasizes the fluidity of the speaker’s identity, suggesting that women should have the right to occupy space in both society and literary history.

An example from this poem where the form and feminist content collide is when the speaker says, “Late-born and woman-souled I dare not hope” (Lazarus 1). This line displays the tension between womanhood and a desire to break free from the traditional roles assigned to nineteenth century women. Also, the use of free verse here emphasizes the internal struggle of the speaker as her thoughts and emotions are not bound by a rigid structure, reflecting the

fluidity of her identity and her desire to assert herself in a literary tradition that was dominated by men.

Another example from this poem is in the lines, “Upon my Muse's lips, nor may I cope / (Who veiled and screened by womanhood must grope)” (Lazarus 4-5). These lines reveal the struggle the speaker faces as a woman artist trying to find her voice in a world that discourages women from participating in public and creative spheres. The journal article titled, “Words and Worlds: Emma Lazarus's Conflicting Citizenships” discusses this line. It states, “The word ‘veiled’ in line five suggests the way in which women were ‘screened’ by their domestic duties, as well as the need for a female artist to hide her work and even conceal her true story in a palimpsest, as Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar have argued” (Lichtenstein 249). What this means is that Lazarus’s choice of the word “veiled” serves as a metaphor for the way women, particularly female artists, were often required to suppress their creative identities. The concept of being "screened" by womanhood refers to the societal expectation that the roles of women should be confined to roles as caretakers, wives, and mothers.

Together, the form and structure of both poems strengthen Lazarus’s feminist message. In “The New Colossus,” she reclaims a traditional poetic form to present a powerful female figure who speaks for the marginalized. In “Echoes,” the more fluid structure reflects the speaker’s struggle to be heard in a world that limits women’s voices. Both poems center women as active participants in shaping public life and cultural identity. Through her use of form Lazarus challenges expectations of femininity and asserts the importance of allowing women in literature and society.

Both Emily Dickinson and Emma Lazarus use poetic form as a tool to express feminist ideas and fight the gendered restrictions of their time. While their styles and subjects differ, each

poet manipulates structure to assert women's agency and challenge the societal expectations placed upon them.

Dickinson does this by working within the common meter and interrupting it with dashes and irregular phrasing. This is an example of how she uses structure to subtly critique societal expectations. In "Much Madness is divinest Sense," for example, her unconventional punctuation emphasizes resistance to conforming. While in "The Soul selects her own Society," she uses a more controlled form and sudden pauses to assert the speaker's independence and autonomy.

On the other hand, Lazarus works within structured forms like the sonnet in "The New Colossus," using its traditional authority to elevate a female figure as a symbol of strength and national identity. While in "Echoes," she uses free verse and loosens the structure to reflect the speaker's struggle for expression in a world that limits women's voices.

Altogether, while the form and content of both Dickinson's and Lazarus's poetry work hand in hand to assert their resistance to society's roles for them, the ways they approach this resistance reveal the depth and range of feminist expression in nineteenth-century poetry. Dickinson's use of hymnal meter and unconventional punctuation reflects a pushback against the expectations placed on women, while Lazarus's use of both sonnet form and free verse reflects the need for women to have an equal voice in the dominant society.

Lastly, their poems continue to resonate today as they serve as reminders to readers that poetry can challenge boundaries and amplify those often left unheard. Dickinson and Lazarus showcase that poetic form is not just a stylistic choice, but a powerful means of resistance. Through their use of blending feminist content with traditional forms, they create lasting works that still inspire questions about gender roles, power, and identity.

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